



DER BERCHTASLAAF - ZWELFDI NACHT 31. YUULING, 2018

ROBERT LUSCH (MIT DENKI ZUM BRIAN WEIS)
REV-D7

Honoring: Berchta, Berchtold

Intonation of the Runes

Each rune intoned thrice: Baerke (Berkano), Loch (Laguz), Fackel (Kenaz), Daag (Dagaz)

Die Heiliching - The Hallowing

*Hammer un Sichel, weihet daer Aldaar un die Schtell
Hammer and Sickle, make holy this altar and this place
Beschitzt uns mit der Graft vun de Ziewe,
Protect us with the Power of the Deities
Bei Wudan un Frigg fer der Gemeeschaft zu baue
By Wudan and Frigg to build the community
Bei Ziu un Zisa fer die Gerechdichkeet un der Fruchsfriede zu erhalde
By Tyr and Zisa to uphold justice and frith
Bei Frey un Freya fer die Wohldaat zu schneide un sammle
By Frey and Freya to cut and to collect the bounty
Bei Dunner un Siwwa fer es Volk vollzumechtige.
By Thor and Sif to empower the Folk
Bei Berchtold fer uns iwwer die Brick zu bringe
By Berchtold to bring us over the Bridge
Bei Fraa Holle un Fraa Berchta un fer es Volk zu erneire
By Fraa Holle and Fraa Berchta to renew the Folk
Wie schmittet der Hammer die Sichel,
As the Hammer forges the Sickle
So die Sichel der Hammer fiedert.
So the Sickle feeds the Hammer
'S iss es Lewesraad, zu saehe un zu schneide
It is the Wheel of Life, to sow and to cut
Hammer un Sichel, weihet daer Aldaar un die Schtell
Hammer and Sickle, make holy this altar and this place.*

Heel!

Heel!

Heel!

Unser Zweck - Our Purpose

Heit sammle mir uns do, fer die Haerrin Berchta un Harr Berchtold zu ehre.

Heel zu de Ziewe!

Heel zu de Wichde!

Heel zum Land!

Heel zu der Gmeeschaft!

Der Aaruf - The Invocation

Invocations to Berchta and Berchtold will be made both in Deutsch and in English.

Es Opfer un Die Eed - The Offering and the Oaths

Losst uns enniche Opfer uff der Aldaar adder in 's Feier yetz schtelle

Un wann ennichebber hot en Eed zu bschweere, kumm yetz voraa.

If anyone has any offerings, please place them onto the altar, or, later, into the fire.

If anyone has any oaths to take, come forward now.

Die Heiliching vun de Opfer - The Hallowing of the Offerings

Die Ausdeeling - The Distribution

Der Sege - The Blessing

When pouring the libations, all say (choose either language):

Vun de Ziewe zu der Erd zu uns

Vun uns zu der Erd zu de Gedder

From the gods to the Earth to us

From us to the Earth to the gods

'N Gschenk fer 'n Gschenk

Heele!

A gift for a gift.

Hail!

Zum Schluss - In Closing

Zu de Wichde - To the Wights

At Midnight: Crack the whip (representing that of Holle or Berchta), bang pots, shoot air guns, etc., to drive away negativity and to reset the calendar, although Yule continues until sundown on January 1.

TOPICS FOR DISCUSSION

Berchta

Berchta is a goddess most likely of the *Wane*. She is seen either as a sister to Holle or as Holle by another name. Her holiday is 31. Yuuling (December) on the current calendar. As is the case with many Teutonic goddesses, She is known for spinning. In the post-Heathen era, Her honor has been tainted by the Church, though the horrid masks that appear as depictions of the Wild Hunt in parts of Germany and Switzerland carry both a fear and a respect for the powerful goddess.

She seeks order in our lives, particularly lucidity of thought. This is, perhaps, akin to this time of introspection and the forming of New Year's Resolutions.

She has a definite "dark" angle to Her, but buried within this aspect is a reflection of the dark side within each of us. We observed, recognized, and even embraced these aspects of ourselves during the time of Belsnickel and Krampus prior to Yule. There is also value in assessing this side of us now we work on improving ourselves in the coming year.

The Berchtaslaaf, or the Progression of Berchta relates to legends that She roams on Her feast day and may appear as a beggar. This observance features a feast that includes gruel and fish, which is Berchta's prescribed meal. Urglaawer typically make the fare to consist of herring and oatmeal or dumpling and herring meal (Grimm, *Teutonic* 273). Some folks, particularly our Frankish brethren in Canada, also make Zemmede (also known as Zemmete, Semmede, and a few other variations) as part of Berchta's meal. Zemmede turn up in a number of practices among the Deitsch, too, and we include them in our Twelfth Night observances.

This meal is a meal of subsistence, perhaps reflecting the starving away of the old year. It stands in contrast to the lavish meal of the Feast of Luul on January 1. It is said that if the meal is not consumed and offered to Berchta on Her feast day, she will slit open the bellies of those who partake of other foods while ignoring Hers, and she will replace the contents with straw. While this certainly may be read literally, it may also be a metaphor for a loss of luck or of food or wealth in the upcoming year.

Lentils may be strewn about or set out as offerings to Berchta. A common Deitsch tradition tonight is to put a coin (or coins) outside on your windowsill overnight tonight. Some variations specify that the coin/s should be silver. Others specify three denominations (nickel, dime, quarter, etc.) of coin. Some Christian interpretations are that these are for the Magi on their way to Bethlehem (PA? lol), while other interpretations definitely have this related to magic that easily fits in with Berchta making the rounds as a beggar. If the coin/s are still there in the morning, bring them back in and "Was hawwich yetz wa ich ganzes Yaahr haawe." ("What I have now I will have all year.") If the coins are gone, then the need was greater elsewhere, and you will receive good luck for aiding another.

The owl is sacred to Berchta and is known for its wisdom. Historically, among the Christian Deitsch, there was a malediction towards the depiction of owls in drawing or in print, and they were often associated with witches (a connection to Berchta) and cast in a negative light. In the continuing paranoia of witches, owl carcasses were also nailed to the sides of sheds or barns in an attempt to frighten off other owls or to protect against evil spirits. Practitioners of Braucherei,

however, never bought into this taboo against this "heathen" practice.

Berchtold

The scant lore on Berchtold leads me to the following:

- 1). Given that Berchtold is seen as sometimes being at the head of the Wild Hunt, there is "something" there that requires more research;
- 2). Competing proposed origins of the event from different contexts and perspectives may not be any more or less valid than our emerging Heathen perspective, but, as Heathens, we would be remiss in our spiritual endeavors if we did not explore our angles as thoroughly as possible;
- 3). The placement of the Berchtoldstag observance is quite possibly a result of calendar shifting related to Epiphany, the Protestant Reformation, and other influences. Since no one knows the true origins of the observance, no one knows how it got to the current date, either;
- 4). The lore that states that men would go about town pressing others whom they encounter to drink to Berchtold is interesting. One of the possible roots of Berchtold is dialectic "berchten," which means "to walk around asking for food." This brings up a little-known Deutsch entity, Bechtel or Bechdel, who is associated with begging and definitely who needs more research in this context. This could be a crucial connection;
- 5). Keeping in mind that Berchta commands a bare-bones meal on Twelfth Night, we could be seeing something related to the hunger from that meal. The pressing of others could also be a test of faith (which has come up in discussions before), and the wandering sounds akin to wassailing or New Year's greetings, which are intended also to elicit hospitality from those visited;
- 6). Conjecture: Nuts, which are related to this observance in Alemannic areas, are potential life, and that is the point on the cycle where we currently are. If Berchtaslaaf is the end of Yule, the "death" of the calendar year, etc., then perhaps Berchtold can be viewed through a lens of the things that bridge death to new life. It may be useful as part of the research process to examine commonalities between Berchta (and, perhaps Berchtold) and "Father Time" types of lore. Additionally, we already honor Lollus/Luul at this time... Lollus' sole depiction is that of a child holding His tongue. Could there be a link between Lollus/Luul and "Baby New Year" types of lore?;
- 7). Keeping in mind that there is still a lot of speculation here, my inclination is, until we know more or our understanding evolves, to honor Berchtold alongside Berchta on Twelfth Night. As some of you may know from Berchta's meal discussion on the Kochkunscht guild, the meal requirement appears to run on the calendar day of December 31 (Eleventh Day (Dec. 31 reckoned by nightfall) and especially Twelfth Night (January 1 reckoned by nightfall).

In a similar manner, Berchtold could be honored at the beginning of Twelfth Night (sundown December 31, which actually begins January 1 since a "day" starts at sunset the prior evening) through the end of Yule (sunset on January 1, which, by nightfall reckoning would begin January 2).

This would create a "bridge" time of the specific honoring Bercha and Berchtold from sunset on Twelfth Night until sunrise on Twelfth Day, and it would create another bridge time of the specific honoring Berchtold and Luul from sunrise January 1 through sunset January 1 (again, sunset starts January 2).

There is at least one other way to consider the reckoning, but this is how I am planning to observe the end of Yule this year. Over the course of the next year, I'm hoping that we can get insights and lore from folks in Switzerland and Liechtenstein.